



“I EXPECT FOOD INFLATION TO COME DOWN FROM OCTOBER”

NITI Aayog Member Ramesh Chand on the impact of climate change on the farm sector, and what needs to be done

BY **SURABHI**

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RAMESH CHAND, MEMBER of the policy think tank NITI Aayog, highlights several reasons for high food prices in recent years, including the Russia-Ukraine war. One factor that poses a significant challenge is climate change. It is already impacting cropping patterns, he says, and though technology has helped counter it for now, there is an urgent need to address the problem. Edited excerpts:



How do you see extreme weather events related to climate change impacting cropping patterns and food output in the coming years?

Climate change manifests in many ways. One is that farmers change production choices. For instance, if they are cultivating wheat, which is sensitive to climate change, there is a possibility that they could be forced to choose a hardy crop as a substitute. Second, the increase in temperature and change in rainfall pattern affect yields and productivity. The impact on productivity will be seen in the long run because, at present,



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there is some possibility of countering the adverse effect of climate change by developing new varieties and new practices. But there is a tipping point beyond which we can't develop new varieties. We have been able to counter the effect of climate

change on productivity in the past few years, but its impact is clearly visible on cost. The real cost of production is increasing as farmers are trying to cope with it. They will try to use more input just to maintain yield. It is a really serious issue.